

LEADERSHIP WITH DATA

Data Leaders eat the frog: Cut toxic hires (New Inherited)

Spot red flags, probation matrix, exit tree



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2



1

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A quote from Mark Twain

Intro: Gut > SQL

Picture this data team: pipelines humming, until one engineer's
~~read-swine torch trust. "Good day? Brilliant SQL wizard. Red~~

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Data leaders know: technical chops hire easy, but gut flags emotional volatility that compounds technical debt. [Gallup pegs disengagement at ~17%-21% globally, spiking churn to 30%+ in data roles-€50k+ per bad fit in Berlin salaries](#). Brittle marts and outages demand steady adults, not rollercoasters.

This playbook arms CDOs/VPs: funnel probes, probation tests, reckoning paths (PIP/redeploy/cut). Own the reality-lead mediocrity without mercy for your stars.

Toxic Flags & Matrix

High skill masking these = **pure poison**. Spot early, cut ruthlessly.

- **Blame/Defensiveness**: "Upstream broke it." retro fights.
- **Diva Demands**: "Task beneath me." entitlement/special treatment
- **Stress Meltdowns**: Cracks under light pressure (deadlines/feedback).
- **Idle Chatter**: Endless Slack while pipelines break/outages rage
- **Knowledge Gatekeeping**: "Only I touch prod," hoards access/secrets.
- **Negativity Drain**: Constant complaints, poisons morale.
- **Credit Hogging**: Steals team wins, ghosts failures.
- **Over-Engineering Ego**: "Simple is stupid," blocks velocity.
- **Condescension**: "That's not how real engineers code."
- **Passive Aggression**: Sarcasm, silent treatment in standups

Data Hit: [High skill toxics cost €12k-50k/year each \(turnover/productivity\)](#). [1 toxic = 54% higher good hire quits](#); Team velocity **-30-40%**.

Rule: Never PIP any 2+, especially repeated pattern. Vampires tar 3x bad code.

Decision Matrix

Assess team hires on **Skill** (delivery), **Behavior** (flags above), and **Trajectory** (trend). No vibes-act.

Behaviour score vs flags above.

Dimension	Positive Trajectory (Improving)	Flat Trajectory	Negative Trajectory (Declining)
High Skill	Keep/Invest Stars scaling impact.	Cut Fast Ex: SQL wizard who blames "upstream," poisons retros. No PIP.	Cut Immediately Toxicity worsening— energy vampire.
Medium Skill	Coach/Redeploy Good behavior + upside.	30d PIP Grrr mediocre (Hirschi-style). Exit if miss metrics.	Cut Can't fix downward slide.
Low Skill	Train if Behavior Good Potential fit elsewhere.	PIP or Redeploy Assess fixability.	Cut No path forward.

- **How to use:** Score post-probation (1-90d data). Document for HR/legal. One bad hire = €50k drag (in Berlin case) + morale hit
- **Example Scenario:** Engineer nails pipelines (high skill) but tanks retros with blame (bad behavior, flat trend) → Cut. Save 3 months velocity loss.

Prevention: Funnel + Probation

Shift Left = Prevention

DevOps: Test early, fix cheap. Hiring: Screen toxics pre-offer –

same math.

JD (Job Description) Design

- Embed must-haves in addition to data skills: communication, emotional stability, resilience; list HM-desired traits (e.g. “owns outages without blame”).
- TA/HM co-craft to filter CVs pre-ATS – avoids buzzword floods from the start for the initial period
- Risk: blame culture under pressure. Screen for: outage ownership, feedback reception. Hard-block: defensive blame wh challenged.

ATS/Recruiter

- Basic screening admins: Flag job-hoppers, blame rants; probe “toughest feedback?” for reflection, personality traits. Find strong profile for HM consideration
- 3 Example questions & Expected anti-pattern:
 - 1. “Toughest feedback? What changed?” Fail: “Politics.”
 - 2. “Outage hits revenue – mock retro.” Fail: Blame.
 - 3. “When team disagree?” Fail: “I’d push.”

HM/Task Stage

- Beyond skills, ask “Outage blame story?” to test accountability – defensive vibes are instant no-go. Live feedback reveals tr personality under pressure.
- Red Flag: Metric debates 10min, ignores actual impact.

Team Fit

- Handling disagreement (mock retro); vote on bad-day fit
- If 1-2 senior people raise specific behavioural concerns, hir manager must either reject or write down a conscious override rationale to the panel.

Hiring Committee decision

- Factor in feedback collected about soft skills as an important decision-making factor
- **Committee**: Soft skills 50%. Flags? **Override**: Written rational or no offer.

Probation Matrix

[Hirschi's containment](#) starts here: Spot **Grrr + Toxic Flags** early

Probation Matrix: 90-Day Proof or Exit

Days	Must-Deliver	Behavior Check	Fail → Action
0-30	3-5 intros + notes; 1 PR; runbook.	Prepared 1:1s; no gossip.	Coach.
31-60	Own domain; 1 incident.	Accepts retro input.	Warning + HRBP.
60-90	1 impact win (SLA signed off).	Peers: "Fight to keep?"	Cut review.

For EU countries, there would still be an extended observation period (i.e. 90d-180d). The goal remains the same: **either** build a clear keep-case (documented impact, behavioural proof) **or** exit decisively before protection and works council dynamics kick in.

Reckoning: Cut > PIP

Toxics Kill P&L

Cut fast or bleed. HRBP/VP loop immediately. Grrr self-fixes are almost never – force decision is the remedy.

Paths (loop team early for damage control):

1. **Cut**: Pure toxicity/high skill bad behavior. 2wk probation not in EU countries.
2. **PIP (Performance Improvement Plan)**: HRBP-tied 30-60d plan. Tangible fixes (e.g., “retro participation sans blame”). Warnings logged; If it works, everything goes back to normal; it doesn't, pick one:
 - 2-3 concrete objectives with metrics and behaviour:
 - “No incidents of public blaming in meetings.”
 - “Close 3 Jira tickets per sprint in domain X with <1 rollback.”
 - Weekly check-ins, written summaries.
 - Explicit pass/fail statement: “If these are not met by <date>, we will terminate the contract.”
3. **Redeploy**: Big-company salvage – move the person to another team in the same company. A much easier and faster way out without legal risk or further energy drain.
 - Redeploy only if:
 - There is a concrete role where their weaknesses matter less (e.g. IC data dev to back-office tools).
 - The host manager is fully briefed and opts in.

- Anti-pattern: "kicking the can to another team" just spread the problem.

Own it – Avoidance breeds mediocre spread.

In addition, stakeholder handling:

- *HRBP & Manager Email: 'Cut/PIP on X – sync?'*
- Team Comms: 'X transitioning roles, thanks for collab.'

Inherited Underperformers: Same Matrix, Faster Clock

New promo or team handoff? Half your fires are legacies – don't inherit the drag.

Apply the decision matrix Day 30:

- High skill toxics? Cut priority – blame culture spreads.
- PIP inherited grrr? 21d max (not 30)–urgency higher.

Day 1 Ritual:

1. 1:1 all: "Strengths? Gaps? 90d goals?" Document.
2. Rank team (private): Top 20% allies, bottom audit.
3. HRBP sync: "3-6mo cleanup plan."

Brutal truth: Reset expectations fast or lose stars. €100k+ velocity preserved vs slow bleed.

Leader Pledge: Eat the Frog

Being a leader is hard. Being a good leader is even harder. Yet cutting toxics is a necessary evil – cut 1 to save 10 stars from the weed. It is very likely that no one will thank you for this; Resentment could be expected instead. Nevertheless, it is more

likely that you got resent for this decision.

Trust me, most of the people will understand as time passes. It is better than another way around.

What I commit to now (and you should too): Screen toxics shift-left from hiring funnel – no buzzword hires. Run 90d matrix proof, cut decisively if fails. Loop HRBP/VP in ASAP, document every fact. Misplaced mercy delays kill your (and the team's) wellbeing and P&L.

Truth: Pain now beats 5-6 digits bleed. One vampire = 54% star quits, -40% velocity.

It was my mistake to keep the "medium and toxic" longer than I should have, and I paid the price of mental labor. Never again – and I am pledging you **learn from my painful lesson, or else you re: learning it yourself in the hard way.**

Run matrix this sprint. Share wins/misses–tag Data Biz. Stars retained, org accelerates.



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